Owney data collection process

Smithsonian Open Access dataset | Snapshot 22 September 2026 UTC

This note records the sources, retrieval method and basic statistics for Owney's travel tags. The saved search returned 422 records; a stated selection rule produced 377 tag records. The dataset provides photographs and museum descriptions, but incomplete dates and places limit a precise reconstruction of his journey.

1 Sources and data availability

1. Smithsonian Open Access API documentation - search endpoint, parameters and JSON response structure.

2. Railroad Hotel Owney tag museum record - an example object record with photographs and a museum description.

3. Owney the dog museum background article - historical context, separate from the object dataset.

4. Smithsonian Open Access FAQ - explanation of Open Access and reuse information.

The API supplies structured text and image links. Available fields include a record ID, title, object number, date, place, description, material, dimensions, image URLs and museum record URL. Some fields contain several values. The saved subset marks all 377 records' metadata and all 742 image entries as CC0; these are the API's recorded access labels.

What this dataset supports

The images, descriptions and materials support a visual catalog and selected object stories. A complete day-by-day route needs further research: place labels lack coordinates and most dates are broad. Map coordinates, browsing categories and selected story sequences were added later; generated atmosphere images are also separate from the museum evidence.

2 How the data was retrieved

The original collection used an automated API request and local filtering. These steps describe that process and can also be checked manually using the example on the next page.

1. Search for Owney through the Smithsonian Open Access API using an API key. The request used q=Owney, rows=1000, start=0 and sort=id, with no additional museum or media filter.

2. Save the returned JSON. The response reported 422 matches and contained 422 rows with 422 distinct API IDs, so another page was not needed for this snapshot.

3. Keep records with unitCode equal to NPM and titles containing both whole words "Owney" and "tag", ignoring capitalization. Of 403 NPM search results, 377 passed; 26 other NPM records and 19 records from other units were excluded.

4. Retain the original fields and make a simpler working copy with one row per tag. Copy image URLs from online_media.media; the photographs are separate files, not embedded in the JSON.

Saved evidence: work/owney/search.json holds the 422-row response; analysis.json records the audit; normalized-tags.json holds the 377-row working copy. The audit timestamp is 2026-09-22T04:49:43.813Z. Statistics below were recomputed on 27 September 2026.

3 A simple query to repeat

1. Use a Smithsonian Open Access API key, available through api.data.gov signup. Replace YOUR_API_KEY below with that key. The key is deliberately omitted from this document.

2. Join the following two lines into one URL and paste it into a browser. This is the same query and parameter set recorded in the original retrieval.

```
https://api.si.edu/openaccess/api/v1.0/search
?api_key=YOUR_API_KEY&q=Owney&rows=1000&start=0&sort=id
```

Here q is the search term, rows is the maximum number requested, start is the starting offset and sort=id orders results by ID. For a small first check, change rows=1000 to rows=1. That returns one result while response.rowCount reports the total matches.

3. Read response.rowCount and response.rows, then save the response as search.json. Apply the NPM and title rule on page 1. If a future search exceeds 1,000 results, request start=1000, then 2000, and so on; combine the pages and check for duplicate IDs.

4 Example response

This is an abridged excerpt from the saved 22 September response, showing one actual record. Fields and other rows have been omitted for readability. It is not a new live response; future results may differ.


```
{
  "status": 200,
  "responseCode": 1,
  "response": {
    "rowCount": 422,
    "rows": [{
      "title": "Railroad Hotel Owney tag",
      "unitCode": "NPM",
      "content": {
        "freetext": {
          "date": [{"label": "Date", "content": "1888-1897"}],
          "place": [{"label": "Place", "content": "Iowa"}]
        },
        "descriptiveNonRepeating": {
          "record_ID": "npm_0.052985.18",
          "metadata_usage": {"access": "CC0"}
        }
      }
    }]
  }
}
```


In the complete record, freetext.notes contains the museum’s account of a hotel key token received at Van Horne, Iowa, with no exact date. online_media.media contains an image URL. This shows why a place can be useful even when a precise travel date is unavailable.

Example image link: Railroad Hotel tag photograph

5 Basic descriptive statistics

Unit of analysis: one museum tag record. Unless noted otherwise, percentages use the 377 selected records as the denominator and are rounded to one decimal place. This is a keyword-selected snapshot, not proof that every surviving Owney tag is represented.

Field present in a record	Records	Share
At least one image	377	100.0%
Museum description	376	99.7%
At least one place label	338	89.7%
Date text of any precision	377	100.0%
Material and dimensions	377	100.0%
Object number and museum record link	377	100.0%
Latitude and longitude in geoLocation	0	0.0%

Images: 742 image entries across 377 records, averaging 1.97 per record (median 2; range 1-4). There are 14 records with one image, 362 with two and one with four. These are image entries, not 742 different tags; alternate views belong to the same object.

Date precision

Date wording group	Records	Share
Exact day	61	16.2%
Month only	3	0.8%
Year only	41	10.9%
Range or multiple days	266	70.6%
Approximate	6	1.6%

The date groups were derived from the museum's wording. A "c." or "circa" prefix takes precedence as approximate; a month, day and year is an exact day; a four-digit year is year only. Remaining ranges and multiple-day expressions are grouped together. Rounded shares sum to 100.1%.

The most frequent date is "1888-1897": 246 records (65.3%). It is a broad catalog date, not evidence of a specific visit. Only 61 records (16.2%) provide a single exact day.

Materials and places

Most common material labels, kept exactly as cataloged: "metal" 213 (56.5%), "metal (brass)" 128 (34.0%), "leather" 10 (2.7%), "metal (copper)" 5 (1.3%) and "metal (aluminum)" 5 (1.3%). Other labels account for 16 records (4.2%); generic metal was not reassigned to a specific material.

Places are unevenly detailed: "United States of America" appears in 147 records, Ohio in 20, Massachusetts in 20 and New York in 19. A record can have several place labels. Thirty-nine records (10.3%) have no place field, so these counts do not represent a complete route or numbers of visits.